

Statement & Argument

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Statement and Argument questions give a policy-style statement (usually a yes/no question, such as 'Should X be done?') followed by two numbered arguments, and ask which argument(s) are 'strong' versus 'weak.' A strong argument is relevant to the statement, factually grounded, and addresses a real, practical consequence; a weak argument is superficial, purely emotional, based on a trivial or irrelevant consideration, or simply restates a preference without real justification. The discipline is judging each argument SOLELY on its logical relevance and substance relative to the statement — not on whether you personally agree with its conclusion. This sub-module covers the criteria for a strong argument, the criteria for a weak argument, fully worked examples, the emotionally-appealing-but-weak trap, the technically-true-but-irrelevant trap, and a practical evaluation technique.

1. Criteria for a Strong Argument

A strong argument directly addresses the practical core of the statement, is based on verifiable or widely-accepted facts (not mere opinion or feeling), and considers a real consequence of acting or not acting — it doesn't need to be the ONLY correct view, but it must be substantively relevant.

- Statement: 'Should the use of single-use plastic bags be banned?' Argument: 'Yes, because plastic bags take hundreds of years to decompose and cause severe, well-documented harm to marine ecosystems.' This is strong: factual, directly relevant, and addresses a real practical consequence.

2. Criteria for a Weak Argument

A weak argument is superficial (based on a trivial or cosmetic consideration), purely subjective preference presented as justification, or fails to actually engage with the substance of the statement even if it sounds emotionally persuasive.

- Same statement as above. Argument: 'No, because plastic bags are colorful and convenient to carry.' This is weak: it's a superficial preference that ignores the substantive environmental question the statement is actually raising.

3. Fully Worked Example: Evaluating Two Arguments

Statement: 'Should all students be required to learn a foreign language in school?' Argument I: 'Yes, because bilingual skills significantly improve career opportunities and cross-cultural understanding, as shown by multiple labor-market studies.' Argument II: 'No, because language classes are boring and many students dislike attending them.' Evaluate each independently against the statement's actual substance.

- Argument I is **STRONG**: it cites a concrete, verifiable benefit (career opportunities, supported by studies) directly relevant to whether the requirement is worthwhile. Argument II is **WEAK**: 'boring' and 'dislike attending' are subjective student preferences, not a substantive reason bearing on the actual value or necessity of the policy.

4. The Emotionally-Appealing-but-Weak Trap

An argument can sound persuasive and provoke a strong emotional reaction while still being logically weak, because it doesn't actually provide relevant evidence or reasoning tied to the statement's real-world consequence — emotional force is not the same as logical strength.

- Statement: 'Should the government increase funding for public hospitals?' Argument: 'Yes, because it breaks my heart to see sick people suffering without care.' Despite the genuine emotional appeal, this is weak as an **ARGUMENT** because it offers no substantive reasoning about funding mechanisms, outcomes, or feasibility — it only expresses a feeling.

5. The Technically-True-but-Irrelevant Trap

An argument can state a fact that is entirely true while still being weak, because that fact doesn't actually bear on the specific question the statement is asking — always check relevance to the **EXACT** statement, not just factual accuracy in general.

- Statement: 'Should the company adopt a four-day work week?' Argument: 'No, because the company was founded over fifty years ago and has always followed traditional practices.' This is factually true but weak: the company's age and tradition are irrelevant to whether a four-day week would actually help or hurt productivity and employee wellbeing.

6. A Practical Evaluation Technique

For each argument, explicitly ask: 'Does this address a real, practical consequence of the action described in the statement, backed by something more than personal preference?' If yes, it's strong; if the honest answer is 'not really' or 'it's just an opinion/feeling/trivial detail,' it's weak.

- Applying this test to Argument II in the foreign-language example ('language classes are boring'): does this address a real practical consequence of the **REQUIREMENT** policy itself? No — it's a subjective complaint about the classroom experience, not a reason bearing on whether the requirement is worthwhile. Confirmed weak.

Common Pitfalls

- Judging an argument as strong or weak based on whether you personally agree with its conclusion, rather than its logical relevance and substance.
- Rating an emotionally powerful argument as strong even though it provides no actual reasoning tied to the statement's real consequence.
- Rating a factually true statement as strong even when that fact is irrelevant to the specific question being asked.
- Confusing a trivial or cosmetic consideration (convenience, appearance) with a substantive practical consequence.
- Failing to evaluate each of the two arguments independently, letting a strong Argument I bias the assessment of a weak Argument II.
- Treating 'sounds reasonable' as sufficient, instead of explicitly checking whether the argument is backed by more than personal preference.

Key Takeaways

- A strong argument is relevant, factually grounded, and addresses a real practical consequence of the statement.
- A weak argument is superficial, purely emotional, based on personal preference, or factually true but irrelevant to the statement's actual question.
- Evaluate arguments on logical relevance and substance, never on whether you personally agree with the conclusion.
- Emotional force is not the same as logical strength — a moving argument can still be weak as an argument.
- A factually accurate statement can still be a weak argument if it doesn't bear on the specific question asked.
- Use the explicit test: does this address a real consequence, backed by more than opinion or triviality?

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